

CHAPTER 5 — Three Minutes

Zoe entered the ladies' toilets and locked the main door behind her.

The bolt slid into place with a thick metal click.

Her hand remained on it.

For one second, the restaurant disappeared.

White-painted door.

Lock on the wrong side.

Footsteps moving away down a corridor.

The soft mechanical certainty of someone else deciding when the room would open again.

Zoe pulled her hand back.

This lock was inside.

She had closed it.

She could open it.

The difference had to matter even when her body refused to believe it.

Three cubicles faced three sinks. A broad mirror reflected weak daylight from a frosted window above the tiled wall. The room was plain but clean. No ceiling hatch. No second door. Nothing large enough to conceal a person.

She checked beneath each cubicle.

Empty.

The final one contained a plastic sanitary bin and a toilet-roll holder hanging loose from one screw.

She checked the window.

It opened less than two inches before a metal stop caught it. Beyond

the frosted glass lay the service yard, rubbish bins and the blank side wall of the restaurant. No exit.

Elias had known that from the fire plan.

He had sent her somewhere with one controlled entrance, not somewhere he had merely hoped was safe.

Zoe looked at the watch on her wrist.

Two minutes and fifty-four seconds.

Her breathing sounded louder in the tiled room.

She turned on one tap.

Water struck the basin and covered some of it.

Not all.

Her pulse remained inside her ears.

Elias had known Cain's name.

Not guessed it.

Known it.

The tired driver who complained about traffic, parking charges and vegetarian food had changed when the name entered the conversation. His shoulders had settled. His breathing had slowed. The irritation had disappeared from him without being replaced by panic.

The result had been worse.

He had looked prepared.

Zoe pressed both palms against the edge of the sink.

Her stomach rolled again.

The potato and beans sat heavily after too many hours with nothing. She swallowed and watched herself in the mirror until the nausea reduced.

Her face looked wrong beneath the bathroom light.

Paler.

Older.

A small red mark crossed one cheek where she had slept against the aircraft window. The sweatshirt sleeves were still too long. The backpack remained on her shoulders, both straps tightened until the fabric pressed beneath her arms.

She did not remove it.

One minute and fifty-eight seconds.

Outside, a door struck metal.

Zoe flinched and moved towards the wall before the sound finished.

A second clang followed.

Then laughter.

Two pale shapes crossed the frosted window.

Kitchen staff carrying rubbish bags towards the bins.

One complained about someone called Darren leaving boxes in the wrong place. The other said Darren had been leaving boxes in the wrong place since before either of them worked there.

Ordinary annoyance.

Ordinary voices.

Zoe waited until they disappeared.

One minute and twenty-two seconds.

She thought of the route.

Not the one entered into Elias's phone.

The real route before that.

The pickup time.

The flight.

The photograph.

The address she had memorised because writing it down would have created another object someone could take.

Only two people had known all of it.

Zoe.

And Jackie.

The thought arrived with the same hard simplicity it had carried on the plane.

She told them.

Zoe closed her eyes.

Betrayal.

Choice.

End of story.

That version hurt cleanly.

Anything else allowed questions.

What had happened after Jackie left the house?

Why had she not called?

Why had Cain's people allowed the flight rather than taking Zoe before it?

What would make Jackie give away something she had helped build?

Questions created alternatives.

Alternatives allowed hope.

Hope had become dangerous.

Fifty-four seconds.

Zoe turned off the tap.

The sudden silence expanded.

She could hear restaurant sounds through the wall.

Cutlery touching plates.

A chair scraping.

The hiss of the coffee machine.

A child asking whether peas counted as vegetables if they had touched chips.

The same child from the dining room.

The world continued as though death had not made a telephone call from the car park.

Thirty-one seconds.

Zoe unlocked the bolt, then locked it again.

Her fingers needed to prove that it obeyed her.

The second click sounded different.

It was still only metal moving into metal.

But this time she controlled it.

Twelve seconds.

She watched the second hand move.

Elias had told her exactly three minutes.

Not approximately.

Not until she felt ready.

Exactly.

Zoe unlocked the door when the final second passed.

* * *

The corridor was empty.

She checked the fire-door window first.

The service yard beyond it contained two kitchen workers, four bins and a delivery cage stacked with empty trays.

No one waited beside the door.

Zoe walked towards the restaurant.

Not fast.

The instruction had not included speed, but running would tell everyone she had a reason.

The dining room looked unchanged.

The elderly couple continued sharing their pie.

The mother near the window had begun cutting the crust from a sandwich while both children complained that the crust had already contaminated the middle.

The motorcyclist sat with his helmet on the chair beside him.

The server carried two mugs towards the counter.

Elias was gone.

His half-eaten pie remained on the table beside a glass of water and the tea he had forgotten to finish. The napkin lay folded once, gravy marking one corner.

Zoe stopped beside the booth.

He had said he would not be there.

Knowing did not prevent the empty seat from feeling like

abandonment.

She sat in the same place as before.

The backpack remained beside her, strap looped around her wrist.

Cash lay beneath the edge of Elias's plate.

Enough for the bill.

More than enough.

Zoe placed it on the table and looked towards the mirror behind the counter.

Two men stood beneath the entrance awning.

The first faced the car park, hands resting loosely at his sides. The second stood nearer the glass and used the dark reflection to watch the restaurant behind him.

Cain's people waited differently from ordinary men.

Their shoulders remained slightly forward.

Their weight stayed balanced.

Their eyes moved more than their heads.

They did not need to stare directly. The room was already arranged around what they expected to happen.

Zoe looked down at the table.

They were waiting for her to panic.

Run through the front doors.

Choose the hatchback.

Make herself the only moving object in an open car park.

The server approached with the bill.

"Your dad coming back?"

The question caught her before she could prepare for it.

"He isn't my dad."

"Sorry. The man you're with."

Zoe looked at the empty seat.

"He said to pay."

The server checked the notes.

"I'll bring your change."

"Keep it."

"That's nearly eight pounds."

"He said not to take it."

The server glanced towards the entrance.

Not suspicious.

Curious.

"Everything all right?"

The same question again.

Airport.

Car park.

Restaurant.

Adults asking after the decision had already become complicated.

Zoe could tell him men were waiting outside.

He might call the police.

The police might use her documents.

The documents contained numbers controlled by people who had moved her through the airport.

She looked at the server.

“Yes.”

The word tasted false.

He collected the money and moved away.

Outside, the first man raised one hand to his ear.

Not a phone.

An earpiece beneath the collar.

His head turned towards the service yard.

The second man followed his attention.

Something had changed.

A third figure appeared beside the portable toilets.

Shorter than the other two. Dark cap. Light jacket. He spoke without approaching them.

All three looked towards the restaurant.

None advanced.

Their posture had altered.

The loose certainty was gone.

The first man moved two steps away from the entrance and placed a parked family car between himself and the service yard.

The second changed position to cover the path towards the hatchback.

The third remained near the toilets where he could see both the restaurant and the coach park.

They were closing routes.

Cautiously.

Not hunting a frightened child now.

Accounting for something else.

Zoe's pulse quickened.

They were afraid.

Or uncertain.

She could not yet tell whether there was a difference.

Either way, they had stopped behaving as though the outcome was already decided.

Where are you?

A chair shifted opposite her.

Zoe nearly cried out.

Elias sat in the booth as though he had returned from washing his hands.

Dust marked his left sleeve. A thin line of blood crossed one knuckle. His breathing remained steady, but the man who had argued about baked potatoes had not returned with him.

His eyes had changed.

Not expression.

Focus.

Everything in the restaurant appeared to occupy some measured distance from him.

"Don't react," he said.

Zoe kept her hands on the table.

"You're bleeding."

"Not mine."

Her eyes moved to the knuckle.

"Mostly not mine."

"That is worse."

"Probably."

The familiar uncertainty sounded different from him now.

He lifted the water glass and drank.

"How many?" Zoe asked.

"Three outside. One in the dark saloon. Another vehicle beyond the coach park. Possible driver in it."

"Five."

"Confirmed four. Possible five."

"What did you do?"

"Counted."

"They changed when the man by the toilets spoke to them."

"One of them saw me."

"Saw you do what?"

"Walk past."

"That isn't enough."

"It was for him."

Zoe looked towards the mirror.

The tall man in the black jacket had appeared near the coach park.

He had not approached the others.

They had moved around him.

Not like colleagues receiving instructions.

Like men who had suddenly become aware that the room contained someone higher in a hierarchy they did not fully understand.

"He recognised you."

"Yes."

"From where?"

"A different life."

"They know you."

"That is not the same as knowing me."

"They're scared of you."

Elias set down the glass.

"They're uncertain."

"That looks like fear."

"Fear makes people unpredictable. Uncertainty makes them wait for information."

"What information?"

"Whether the story they heard is standing inside this restaurant."

Zoe studied him.

"Who are you?"

Elias looked towards the window reflection.

"Today, I'm the man taking you to your grandmother."

"That is not an answer."

"No."

"It might not even be true."

His attention returned to her.

Zoe had not meant to say it aloud.

The destination address sat between them without appearing on the table.

Elias did not defend Mac's story.

"That is a problem for after the car," he said.

"And before it?"

"We walk."

"They're covering it."

"Yes."

"You said the restaurant was safer."

"It was."

"Was?"

"They know I'm inside now."

The distinction tightened something beneath Zoe's ribs.

Elias leaned forward slightly.

"When we stand, you stay on my left. Not behind me. Not ahead."

"Why left?"

"So I can see you without turning and they cannot separate us with one person crossing between."

"What if someone speaks?"

"You keep moving."

"What if they touch me?"

"I deal with it."

"You said you wouldn't touch me."

"I said I would not. I did not speak for them."

Zoe looked at the men outside.

"And if they have guns?"

"They will not use them in the middle of a family service station unless the plan has already failed."

"How do you know?"

"I don't."

"That is not comforting."

"It was not intended to be."

She tightened both backpack straps.

Elias noticed.

"Ready?"

"No."

"Good."

"That makes no sense."

"Ready people rush. Frightened people can still follow instructions."

Zoe looked at the empty pie plate.

"Are you frightened?"

"Yes."

The answer arrived without embarrassment.

She looked back at him.

"What do you do with it?"

"Give it a job."

Outside, the tall man moved closer to the path leading from the

restaurant.

Elias stood.

“Walk normally,” he said.